CITY OF DREAMS

Of all the characteristics that Akbar shared with his semi-nomadic Timurid ancestors, perhaps the most enduring one would be his habit to gather up his men, his harem, his soldiery, and his animals, and move. For Timur, as indeed for Babur, a tent in a fragrant garden next to a flowing stream was home. For the Mughals of Hindustan, this tenacious need to be on the move would continue, even as their tented encampments grew ever more elaborate and stately. They would travel to hunt, on battles, on pilgrimages, on adventure, and sometimes just on a whim. The tent in a garden setting was therefore a profoundly evocative image for the Mughals and in Akbar's first great monumental project, after the re-building of Agra, it is not surprising that the layout of Fatehpur Sikri resembles, in its vast, open spaces and centrally located, vertical masses of flat-topped buildings, that same image translated into sandstone.

There is much that remains a mystery about Fatehpur Sikri— the order in which the buildings were constructed, the layout and planning, the purpose of some of the buildings, today often misleadingly named. Many of the original buildings, made of rubble bonded with lime, and gypsum mortar, have crumbled. These include the nobles' houses, the offices of the bureaucrats, the stables, the shops and the bazaars. But from what remains it is easy to gauge the wealth of the empire and the creative vision and energy of the man who willed the city into being when spirits and ghouls were threatening the peace of his house.

The ecstatic impression of visiting travellers gives us some sense of the wonder that this city was in its time. 'Agra and Fatepore,' wrote Ralph Fitch, English traveller to Hindustan in the sixteenth century, 'are two very great cities, either of them much greater than London and very populous… The King hath in Agra and Fatepore as they do credibly report, 1000 elephants, 30,000 horses, 1400 tame deer, 800 concubines: such store of ounces, tigers, buffalo, cocks and hawks that is very strange to see.' And Monserrate thought that 'the splendour of [Akbar's] palaces approaches closely to that of the royal dwellings of Europe. They are magnificently built, from foundation to cornice, of hewn stone, and are decorated both